

Meeting Summary: Harris County Flood Control District/Stella Link & Buffalo Speedway Bridge Update (lead speaker: Gary Zika, P.E., Federal Project Department Manager, HCFCD)

Stella Link Bridge

- **Work begins this coming Monday, July 22, 2019 – Work is expected to take 6 months to complete.**
- The Stella Link bridge is not being torn out; it will be extended 45 to 50 feet to the south, and the retaining wall will be extended as well. Lowering the concrete beneath the bridge will increase the volume of water than can pass beneath the bridge.
- Work will begin on the southbound side of the bridge. The southbound side will be closed, and the northbound side will be temporarily converted to a two-way street, with a single lane in each direction.
- No change will be made to the north side of the bridge or its retention wall, due to soil remediation that is underway in that area. However, the pedestrian ramp on north side of bridge will be replaced.
- The HCFCD hopes to maintain left-turn lanes during construction.
- Once work on the southbound side is complete, contractor will open the southbound side and close the northbound side for construction.
- Signage communicating construction is already in place.
- Once complete, the Stella Link bridge will look like the bridge that was recently completed in the Medical Center. The HCFCD and the City of Houston are still working on enhancements for the Stella bridge, including wider sidewalks in exchange for slightly reduced lane size.

Buffalo Speedway Bridge

- Work is expected to begin in Q1 2020, once the Stella Link bridge is complete [same contractor building both bridges]. Buffalo bridge construction is expected to take one year.
- The force main that runs parallel to the bridge has to be moved as do other utilities prior to tearing out the bridge.
- Once utility work (AT&T) is complete, the Buffalo Speedway bridge will be completely torn out and replaced with a three-span bridge. The new bridge will be longer, wider and higher, with left-turn lanes and 10-foot-wide sidewalks. Sidewalks will be raised 6 to 7" above bridge's driving surface. Bikes and pedestrians will share the sidewalks; separate bike lanes will not be constructed.
- As the bridge nears completion, road construction will begin on North and South Braeswood to build up the street elevation at intersections to match the elevation of the new bridge.
- During construction, Buffalo bridge traffic will detour to Stella Link and Kirby. Signage communicating this change will be in place early, and other efforts are in place to enlist the media's help in communicating the bridge closure.
- The City is aware of the need to adjust traffic lights at Kirby to accommodate increased traffic.

Additional Information Shared:

- Harris County Flood Control District was founded in 1937 following floods in 1927 and 1935.
- Project Brays began in 1998 and has received funds totaling \$350 million to date. The balance of the project was fully funded post-Harvey.
- Most of the project's channel work is done. Four new detention basins have been built, three of which are also parks.
- Project Brays has involved 21 channel modifications and 32 bridge modifications/replacements.
- If neighborhoods wish to enhance the bridges (such as with mosaics), they should contact the COH to discuss.
- The bridge name will appear in print on both sides of each bridge.
- New traffic signals will be installed at Buffalo Speedway (and Greenbriar), but not at Stella Link.

- As the bridges are completed, the Parks Board will follow with construction of the new below-street-level bike paths.
- A pedestrian bridge will be constructed separately near the Stella Link bridge. The precise location of this bridge is still under discussion.
- Completion dates for both bridges could change due to weather or other unforeseen/unpredictable variables.
- Gary Zika also briefly discussed the Greenbriar bridge construction, which is near completion.

Direct any questions about the bridges to:

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